50TH ANNIVERSARY

2005-2015

GROWTH AND ANGER

In this decade, India travelled through sharp contrasts—ambition and drift, empowerment and disillusionment. The early UPA years combined high economic growth with an unprecedented rights-based turn, turning welfare into legal entitlements through RTI, MGNREGA, Aadhaar and food security. Rising global confidence, corporate expansion and sporting triumphs fed a sense of arrival.

That momentum was jolted by the 2008 global financial crisis, which abruptly ended the boom. Repeated terror attacks and Maoist violence exposed deep security failures. From 2010 onwards, a succession of high-profile corruption cases hollowed out trust, paralysed governance and triggered mass protest, culminating in the rise of AAP from the streets. Public outrage over crimes against women led to tougher laws, but justice lagged social change.

The decade closed not in collapse but exhaustion. The electorate set the stage for a decisive political rupture in 2014.